

just as critical. Here are 10 simple meal ideas you can prepare in 10 minutes or less.

1. Tacos

For healthy, fun eating that brings together multiple food groups, tacos are tough to beat. They're also incredibly flexible, with versions available in chicken, beef, fish, and texturized vegetable protein (TVP).

2. Fried rice

For this super-quick inexpensive meal, use pre-cooked rice from a prior assembly-cooking session, or a minute rice, then add almost anything you want. Whether you're using leftover pork ribs, sale ham, or even chopped chicken, fried rice is a great way to use up leftovers of all types. Don't forget the soy sauce.

3. Soup on the fly

While many soups require longer prep times and slow simmering, there are a few ways to get a decent soup on the table in minutes. A restaurant knockoff version of pasta fagioli is one. Onions and celery cook quickly, carrots can be grated to greatly speed up the process, canned beans are already cooked, and most dried pastas

cook in six to eight minutes. Fresh pastas finish in even less time. Slice some leftover artisan bread, add some fun toppers, and you've got an elegant dinner on the table in no time.



4. Gourmet sandwiches

Horseradish-infused tuna melt, oven-toasted ham and swiss, a fresh basil caprese, spread with fun condiments and bargain banana peppers purchased in bulk . . . loads of options exist here for fun dinner food on the run. Add some homemade potato chips or mozzarella sticks and you've got a decently replicated café experience right at home.

5. Dinner salads

There are lots of creative opportunities for salad: chicken caesar, sliced steak, spinach and strawberry with feta and sunflower kernels. The time-saver here is the low number of prep dishes to scrub and scour, and the reduced (or removed) cooking time depending on whether you choose to use precooked meat or grill it up fresh that night. Either way, this strategy puts a healthy, fast, and elegant meal on the table in a flash.